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Culture (OWC): [Azande \(FO07\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Central Africa

Field Date: No Date

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage

Sudan and Democratic Republic of the Congo

Section Title(S): TEMPERAMENT, MANNERS, AND HABITS

The Azande have, moreover, shown an interest in, and a facility for copying, European ways, which, combined with their native manual dexterity, has led European observers to forecast that “ their pliability and relatively high intelligence will cause them to leave all other tribes of the southern Sudan far behind.” ³⁴

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They seem to possess courage, powers of endurance, adaptable intelligence, and craftsmanlike skill, while their political discipline is famous. ³⁵

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The comparative cleanliness of the Azande has also impressed Europeans, who, however, have been repelled by their earlier cannibalism, their relish for putrescent, even liquescent flesh, and their habit of eating without masticating but simply hurling the food down the throat.

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They are accused, like other African peoples, of having no conception of the value of work for its own sake, but only as a means of subsistence. Extra work, either to ensure a surplus of food crops, or to exchange for cash, does not seem to interest them.

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Lelong³⁶ reports that the Mangbetu peoples of the south, particularly the women, are more exuberant and less reserved than the Azande. The Azande enjoy practical **joking** and laughing at others' misfortunes. Yet they are sensitive to chaffing, and ridicule or being mentioned by name in a song can be a serious matter, the sufferer being entitled to appeal to the chief for legal compensation from his abuser. *Sengae* or abuse generally consists of references to the victim's genitals.³⁷

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Humor

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Offenses Against The Person

The Azande, in anger, will fight with knives and clubs, wrestle and slap each other with open hands, but will not use fisticuffs. Greeting and farewell are expressed by joining the middle fingers of the right hand and jerking them together "till they snap and crack again";³⁸ when doing this with a superior, a woman may bow, and both sexes will lower a load or a weapon before a superior as a sign of respect. The Azande do not kiss. In ordinary relations a Zande seems to be cheerful, loquacious, excitable, and generous, though Larken insists that he is also "idle," "improvident," and "untruthful," summing him up as "like a dishonourable school-boy."³⁹

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Ingroup Antagonisms

Both sexes sleep naked, using logs for pillows or wooden headrests. A fire is considered a necessary night comfort, and the Azande do not like sleeping in the dark. Babies and young children sleep in their mothers' arms, and many suffer, like so many African children, from burns caused by rolling into the fire.

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Furniture

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Sleeping

Azande feel damp and cold acutely, and use the same word for both.⁴⁰ They even claim that they smoke as protection against the cold. Both tobacco and hemp are smoked, though they are only lightly cultivated, the latter surreptitiously since European administration. Tobacco pipes, usually about 3 ft. long, are precious possessions, and one of the employments given to small sons is to carry them for their fathers when the latter go on a visit. The smoke is inhaled in one huge puff, which provokes dizziness and near insensibility. There is a suggestion⁴¹ that tobacco is indigenous to the Zande area for, while other tribes of the Bahr el Ghazal use the word *taba*, the Azande use their own *gbakara* or *bagbuduma*. Both sexes smoke.

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Drives And Emotions

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Recreational And Non-Therapeutic Drugs

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Childhood Activities

Azande eat heavily when they can, but, when food is short, seem to bear hunger **18** well, and it is bad manners to seem eager to eat, though this convention is relaxed when the food is termites and meat.⁴² Drunkenness is rare.⁴³

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Diet

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Alcoholic Beverages

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Etiquette

34 Spence, quoted by Maurice, 1930.

35 Culwick, 1950, para. 34, states that this has now often degenerated into servility.

36 1946, vol. II, p. 77.

37 Evans-Pritchard, 16, 1933; blood-brothers have licence, which is not permitted to others, to chaff each other freely in this way.

38 Schweinfurth, 1873, vol. I, p. 442.

39 2, 1926, p. 14.

40 Larken, loc. cit. Although the words given in Canon Gore's *Dictionary* are not identical

41 Larken, 3, 1927, p. 92.

42 Culwick, 1950, para. 193.

43 Larken, op. cit., p. 91.

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